GMAT Timing Decision Card

Sectional Pacing Benchmarks, The 2-Minute Decision Rule & Unfinished Penalty Mathematics

1. Sectional Pacing Benchmarks & Milestone Checkpoints

Memorize these strict milestone timestamps to prevent time deficits from snowballing during your official exam.

Exam Section	Total Qs & Time	Average Time / Q	Checkpoint 1 (1/3 Done)	Checkpoint 2 (2/3 Done)	Checkpoint 3 (Final Str
Quantitative Reasoning	21 Questions / 45 Mins	2 Mins 08 Secs	Q7: 30 Mins remaining	Q14: 15 Mins remaining	Q18: 6 Mins remaining (3 to go)
Verbal Reasoning	23 Questions / 45 Mins	1 Min 57 Secs	Q8: 30 Mins remaining	Q16: 14 Mins remaining	Q20: 6 Mins remaining (3 to go)
Data Insights	20 Questions / 45 Mins	2 Mins 15 Secs	Q7: 30 Mins remaining	Q13: 15 Mins remaining	Q17: 6 Mins remaining (3 to go)

Rule of Thumb: If you are more than 3 minutes behind your checkpoint timestamp, execute an immediate strategic guess.

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2. The 2-Minute Strategic Guess & Move-On Decision Rule

High scorers are not smarter at doing 4-minute math; they are disciplined at abandoning sinking questions in 2 minutes.

Elapsed Time on Question	Cognitive Assessment Question	Decision Action Protocol	Strategic Rationale
At 1 Minute 00 Seconds	"Do I have a clear, working mathematical or logical setup?"	If YES: Proceed with calculation. If NO: Re-read prompt once.	Catch setup errors early before investing heavy calculation time
At 2 Minutes 00 Seconds	"Am I within 30 seconds of reaching a final answer?"	If YES: Finish solving. If NO: Eliminate absurd choices, guess, FLAG, and move on.	Every second past 2:30 steals time from 2 future questions you could get right
At 3 Minutes 00 Seconds	"Why am I still here?"	EMERGENCY ACTION: Pick your favorite letter, click confirm, do not look back.	Spending 3.5+ minutes on one question has a 65% correlation with score drops
Review Phase (End of Section)	"Do I have time to revisit flagged questions?"	Review flagged questions if >= 2 mins remain. You can edit up to 3 answers.	The Edit feature allows you to guess guilt-free during the timed section

Key Mindset: An educated guess is not a failure; it is a tactical sacrifice to protect your overall section percentile.

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3. The Mathematical Penalty of Unfinished Questions on GMAT Focus

Why leaving questions blank is statistically catastrophic compared to guessing.

- The Unanswered Penalty: GMAC applies a severe percentile penalty for every question left unanswered at the end of a section. Your score drops significantly more from 2 blank questions than from 2 guessed wrong answers.
- Never Leave Blank: In the final 45 seconds, if you have 2 questions remaining, click an answer choice for both and submit. Never let the timer expire with blanks.
- The Consecutive Wrong Trap: While guessing is better than blanks, do not guess randomly 4 times in a row if avoidable. Distribute strategic guesses across the section.
- Flagging Protocol: Flag no more than 4-5 questions per section so that you can quickly locate your highest-probability review targets.